
Nishant Dougall

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Subject: Application for General Drug Checking Harm Reduction Peer Worker (Events)

To the Hiring Manager,

I am writing to apply for the General Drug Checking Harm Reduction Peer Worker position. My commitment to this work is born from a profound values-driven journey, which saw me transition from a nine-year career in finance to pursue systemic, meaningful change in community services. For the past four years, I have actively immersed myself in the harm reduction sector, and I hold a deep appreciation for Harm Reduction Victoria's pioneering leadership in peer-led advocacy and community building.

My approach is grounded in my own comprehensive lived experience navigating the complexities of substance use and accessing services. This provides me with a unique dual perspective: I understand the barriers and stigma our community faces because I have faced them, and I know the power of authentic peer connection because I have both sought and provided it. This insight was central to my work as a Harm Reduction Peer Worker at Thorne Harbour Health, where I facilitated bi-weekly support groups, fostering a safe space for meaningful engagement.

My harm reduction experience extends to event-based environments through my work with Thorne Harbour Health, where I provided sexual health and substance use harm reduction support at sex-on-premises venues. These dynamic, peer-focused settings required me to engage with diverse community members in real-time, responsive environments—delivering practical harm reduction information while maintaining the non-judgmental, person-centered approach that is essential to effective peer work.

Through this frontline peer work and ongoing community engagement, I have gained extensive, real-world knowledge of drug markets, emerging trends, and the particular risks associated with novel psychoactive substances. I understand that responding to these challenges requires not only formal knowledge, like that from my Alcohol and Other Drug Skill Set certificate, but also the ability to remain calm and effective in dynamic environments. My experience supporting over 400 vulnerable clients in high-pressure situations at Diamond Valley Community Support has honed my ability to apply de-escalation techniques and person-led support when it is needed most.

It is an incredibly exciting time for harm reduction in Victoria, and I was thrilled to see the announcement of the drug checking implementation trial—a testament to HRVic's integral advocacy. My resume provides further detail on my qualifications, and I am very eager to discuss how my unique blend of lived and professional experience can contribute to this vital new service.

Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,

Nishant Dougall